

Lumbosacral Stenosis (LS Disease)

What is it?

Lumbosacral disease happens when the space around the nerves at the **lower end of the spine** (where the back meets the pelvis) becomes too narrow. Worn discs, arthritic joints and thickened ligaments and tissues press on the nerves.

Common signs

- Lower back pain
- Reluctance to jump
- Tail held low or wagging less
- Trouble posturing to defecate
- Trouble getting up

More serious cases: significant hind-leg weakness, or loss of bladder/bowel control (leaking urine, dropping stool).

Diagnosis

A neurological and orthopedic exam, followed by **MRI or CT** of the lower spine to confirm nerve compression and plan treatment.

Treatment

The choice depends on how severe the signs are and on factors unique to your pet.

Medical management — anti-inflammatory medication (such as prednisone) and/or epidural injections. We try to avoid long-term oral steroids because of side effects, but they provide powerful anti-inflammatory control when needed.

Epidural steroid injections — medication placed directly at the problem area, giving local relief with minimal side effects. Many dogs improve significantly.

- Typical protocol: **3 injections** — day 0, day 14, and about 6 weeks after the first
- Each is done under very light anesthesia; drop off in the morning, home around noon
- If there is no lasting improvement after all three, we will discuss surgery

Surgery — the best option for rapid and usually complete recovery. Recommended when there is significant hind-leg weakness, pain that does not respond to medication, or incontinence. Implants are sometimes needed to stabilize the spine after decompression.

Prognosis

- Medical management: **fair to guarded**
- Surgery: **70–90%** successful outcomes
- If incontinence is present **before** surgery, it usually does not resolve

At home

- Keep your pet lean — extra weight adds strain on the back
- Use ramps and avoid jumping in and out of cars and furniture
- Use a harness rather than a collar for walks
- Call us if pain worsens, weakness develops, or there are changes in urination or bowel control